

From Shellfish to Rice Paddies: Reassessing the Jomon-to-Yayoi Food

Transition

Beneath the mudflats of Japan's Pacific coast lie mounds of shell built up, generation after generation, by hands that fed themselves on clams, oysters, and whatever the tide gave up. For more than ten thousand years, the hunter-gatherer communities archaeologists group under the label "Jomon" lived this way, drawing on shellfish, marine and terrestrial mammals, and a wide range of wild plants to build one of the longest-lived non-agricultural traditions in ~~world~~ archaeology. Then, as early as the eleventh century BCE, something changed: communities in the archipelago began cultivating wet rice (*Oryza sativa*), and within a few centuries the crop had spread west to east across most of Japan, eventually giving its name to the following Yayoi period (Leipe et al. 2020). Why did coastal Jomon communities, whose diet had sustained them for millennia, move toward a labor-intensive grain, and what did that shift actually change about their relationship to food? Drawing on archaeobotanical, zooarchaeological, and stable isotope evidence, I argue that the transition was neither sudden nor complete. Rather than replacing foraging outright, coastal communities folded rice into an existing subsistence base over many generations, a pattern archaeologists call "low-level food production" (Smith 2001). What changed was not simply what people ate, but how they related to food itself, as communities moved from an economy built around the immediate, seasonal availability of wild resources toward one increasingly built around the deferred, storable yields of a cultivated grain—a shift set in motion as much by upheaval on the Asian mainland as by anything happening within Japan.

Understanding what changed requires knowing what the Jomon diet looked like before rice ever arrived. The clearest archaeological signature of that diet is the shell midden: a refuse

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Isn't this associated with an influx of new people?

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But wasn't the spread of this technology also accompanied by the movement of new peoples into the region?